

ANUSHKA MENON

LISTENING TO HER SITAR

Nominated for two Grammy Awards this year, Anoushka Shankar has returned to India for a concert tour. She explains why she picks expansiveness when it comes to both her genres and her attitude

Q+A

Q. Your India tour is a ritual now. You couldn't come for two years because of the pandemic. Did you miss it?
The fortune of coming back frequently is that somewhere it continues to feel like a home and not just the place you came from once. It keeps the connection alive. You still know the pulse of a place, the restaurants, the details... that stuff is important to feel you're at home. If I'm away from India for too long, it starts to feel like it's not mine anymore. So, I'm impatient to return.

Q. Is there a conscious effort on your part to show audiences that the sitar can go beyond the classical spectrum?
More than audiences, there's a conscious curiosity on my part to see what the sitar can do. I love cross-cultural connection and learning from other people. I love trying to work within different traditions. It's important to grow.

Q. You are presenting an extended version of 'In Jyoti's Name' at the Mumbai concert. It was a track triggered by the aftermath of the 2012 gang-rape case in Delhi...
We were all traumatised by the horrors. The world was talking about rape and violence against women at the time, and what we needed to do for things to change. It is important to return to it 10 years later, on the anniversary of her attack, and create an offering of music, because, really, what has changed? What is better?

Q. Already a seven-time Grammy nominee, you are up for two awards this year. Do you covet that trophy?
Not necessarily. Obviously, you hope to win and it's disappointing not to. But I also don't think anyone is owed a win. I try to stay grateful to be nominated.

with Suhani Singh